

OREGON CITY COURIER

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MAINLY ABOUT TAXES

Two men were discussing land values in western Clackamas county last week. One of them said he would be glad to buy a farm here, and locate, only that there was such a vast difference between the assessed valuation of farms, upon which the owners paid taxes, and the price these same owners put upon their farms when they were asked to sell them. The stranger didn't think it was right to be asked to pay \$400 an acre for land one mile out from the inter-urban line—unimproved, raw land, at that; when the assessed valuation of this property was given as less than \$150 an acre. And so the man didn't buy.

Shortly after hearing this discussion, there came to the Courier a copy of a letter sent by the Chicago Liquor Dealers' Association to members of Congress at the time when Congress was considering adding about 25 percent of taxes to the liquor trade so as to increase the national revenues cut down by the European war. A part of this letter reads as follows:

"We also wish at this time to call your attention to a class of property that seems to have been treated with remarkable solicitude by Congress. We refer to property in land. We cannot conceive of a fairer method to all classes than a tax on land values. In common with other business men we are the prey of the owner of land values, with this exception that we are generally charged 50 to 100 percent higher rents. It seems unfair to impose on the men of our nation who strive and work and hustle the entire tax burden and then allow those who reap the greatest income with the least effort to practically escape all national taxation. We, therefore, ask you to study the question of a tax on land values if it is found to be necessary to increase the national income."

"A tax of this kind will be opposed by all wealthy parasites, by all the great land-holding speculators, but we do not think any objections which these interests may offer should be given much consideration by Congress. Men who withhold useful land from use while hundreds of thousands of willing workers are unemployed, should not be exempted from their just share of taxation."

"A tax on land values would be fair to all, would be an inexhaustible source of all necessary revenue for the maintenance of our government, and would be the means of giving employment to thousands of men by forcing into use an immense area of valuable idle land."

And after reading the copy of that letter, and hearing the discussion in regard to land values hereabouts, we recalled the vast expenses in Oregon that are held for speculation. And we also wondered what was going to happen to taxes next year, when Oregon goes "dry."

And considering these several things, we examined our mental condition and discovered that we were "thinking single tax."

Of course the Chicago liquor dealers were trying to pass the buck when they wrote as they did to Congress. And of course the man whose property is assessed at \$175 an acre, and who wants \$400 an acre for it, is trying to pass the buck on to the poor fool who may buy it. And of course when prohibition of the coming Oregon kind goes into effect next year there will be more passing the buck in regard to taxes. And with this constant passing of the buck to and fro—well, we can't just blame some people for talking single tax as a possible remedy.

It seems to us right now that if single tax is such a bad thing as its opponents say it is, one of the best ways to stave it off—in Oregon at least—would be to put the price of idle land down somewhere near an attractive price to the poor buyer.

MORE ABOUT ROADS

The Courier trusts that those interested in road reform in Clackamas county—both officials and just ordinary taxpayers—will read the following remarks of the Oregon Voter, and will ponder upon them.

A heater that gives no heat is about as useful as a bank that gives no service. This Bank gives you Service plus Safety.

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Again this year Oregon is expending nearly \$5,000,000 of local tax money for county and district roads. "Of this, at least \$3,500,000 is being expended for repairs. The roads will receive little permanent benefit. The work must be done over and over again the following year."

"Road taxes run from 5 mills to 10 mills in many of the counties. If one mill only were diverted from the local county and district road taxes to a state highway fund, it would yield \$900,000 to be expended in permanent improvement of trunk highways—would hard-surface 50 miles or more a year. In ten years this would be 500 miles of fine highway, upon which there would be little annual maintenance cost. The roads would be an asset to the state, instead of a dusty or muddy liability requiring \$3,000,000 or \$4,000,000 a year for makeshift upkeep."

"We are spending more per capita for roads in Oregon than most other states. But we are not getting enough for the money. Our salvation will be to divert part of our present heavy expense into permanent construction. Then we will have something to show for our money at the end of every year."

The Courier would have it particularly noted that the state is going to spend three and a half million dollars for road repairs.

These and a half million dollars is considerable money. It is TOO MUCH FOR REPAIRS, even when roads are in the condition of Oregon roads. Roads that cost three and a half million dollars in one year to repair are NOT WORTH REPAIRING.

It would be better to take this three and a half million dollars and start building new roads with it.

The state of Washington has much better roads than Oregon, yet it has practically the same climatic and geographical conditions. Washington, when it feels very prosperous, sometimes lets its state highway commission spend two million dollars a year for its trunk roads. And because the Washington highway commission is in charge of competent road engineers, who know how to build serviceable roads, its highways last and endure. For four million dollars, appropriated five years ago, Washington put down its famous system of scenic highways that make travel from the Canadian border, through the Sound country, and over the Cascades, a pleasure both to tourists and farmers. This four million dollars was put into roads in a little over two years—and since it was extended repairs have been practically nil.

The three and a half million dollars that Oregon counties are going to dump into ruts and mudholes this year would give this state just as good and just as serviceable roads as Washington has, provided it was spent with brains and for roads. As it is, most of it probably will be spent with supervisors and for petty graft.

It is about time that all of Oregon, and Clackamas county in particular, woke up to the fact that it takes brains and training to build a road just as it takes brains and training to do any other kind of special work.

REFRESHING NEWS

While it is still a long way from election, there comes to us a very much "pre-election" speech delivered by State Senator Will H. Paulhamus, the wizard of the Puyallup fruit and farming region. Mr. Paulhamus, who has shown Washington farmers—and particularly the owners of small farms—how to make real profits by co-operation in all lines, dropped into North Yakima recently in the course of his business, and there announced that he would like to be governor.

The way Mr. Paulhamus said it was a novelty—a distinct novelty in political circles. He started in by admitting that he wanted to be governor, said next that he only cared for one term, and promised if he was elected to upset all the political machines he could find. Such a program is not often announced by aspirants for political honors in this nation of ours. Most of the would-be office holders are more circumspect in their language. But Mr. Paulhamus

is not an average man. He not only believes in helping his fellows, even if it costs him money; but he has the habit of also meaning what he says. In view of this, and in view of the crying need for a new sort of gubernatorial timber in all the Northwestern states, the Courier feels that a quotation from the remarks of Mr. Paulhamus may not be amiss at this time. It will furnish a model by which local candidates should guide themselves, and it will furnish a fine standard to which they ought to measure up.

"If I am elected governor," said Mr. Paulhamus, "I will be the most different sort of governor this state has ever seen. I will go in the back way, with broom in hand, ready to sweep out an army of incompetents and loafers. Mine would be a 'business' administration from start to finish. The first announcement I would make would be that I was not a candidate for reelection. After that I could do business."

"I think my election is possible, I expect in the course of my trips around the state to ask frankly what leaders think of my possible candidacy. If they approve of it I shall be grateful. If they do not, then I am through with my investigation I shall be ready to announce definitely whether I will be a candidate."

"Some of my friends have suggested I owed it to the people of the state to give up my thoughts of being governor to work for and with fruit growers. As far as that goes, I could serve them better as governor than I can now. What I did would have more prestige than it does now. And I expect to have the fruit situation well in hand by the time election comes."

neck of the woods. At first it appeared that there was to be something really done, but as in former spasms of official virtue regarding the slaughtering of a family by a degenerate armed with a handy axe, the present spasm seems to be developing into nothing more than a publicity game. It is too bad that something cannot be done in regard to the Hill case aside from the printing of columns of fine-sounding but idle words. It really WOULD be good politics for some office seeker to actually bring justice in the case, instead of just talking about it.

Wolf Howls

Clackamas county is well advertised by its humorists, intentional and otherwise. Rex Lampman, who lives at Oak Grove and writes funny stuff in the Journal, is constantly telling of the eels that infest the county bathing beaches; and Edward Moriarty, of the Daily News, who camps near Jennings Lodge, is also frequently remarking on Rex's love of eels. Dean Collins, who tries to be funny on the Oregonian, also devotes considerable space to this county from time to time; while Mr. McKetchnie of the Enterprise, keeps the Telegram posted in his inimitable way on our doings. And besides these we have Chris Schuebel and George C. Brownell.

It is to be noted that the benevolent power trust that prevails in our midst places its meters usually on the back porch, in full view of all who dare

I didn't have anything on, and I keep looking down constantly to see what is the matter."

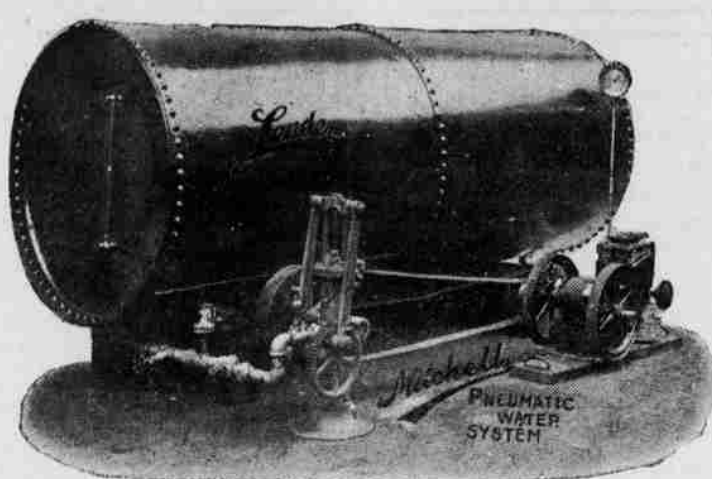
Mayor Linn E. Jones, of Oregon City, who recently shipped back to Portland a keg of port wine, and who had to take it back again because the wholesale house wouldn't accept it, says that the keg has lost half its contents since it began its travels. Which shows that it is hazardous to ship liquor through "dry" territory.

Lloyd Riches is the strongest man in Clackamas county. Recently when he wasn't invited to accompany Tom Burke and Judge Sievers on their search for fish, poison oak and deer in the mountains, Lloyd said that "when he was in his prime 'he thought nothing at all 'of carrying a fifty-pound pack for thirty miles a day through the brush.'" Seeing as Lloyd weighs almost fifty pounds, this is some stunt.

Women have cleaner minds than men, they tell us. They ought to have—they change them more frequently.

A government report on China contains a paragraph devoted to "crops, floods, bandits and general conditions." With all these things China must surely be getting civilized.

Study of this China report, incidentally reveals some surprising things. China's greatest export to the United States last year wasn't tea or chop-sui or paper lanterns—it was \$17,590,930 worth of beans. And her greatest import from this nation was over \$52,000,000 worth of cotton yarn. Thus our accepted ideas about China must be changed.

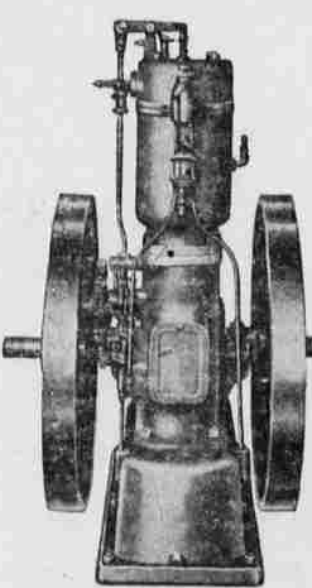


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HAPPY THOUGHT

Last week two more amateur detectives bobbed up at the county seat, requesting the court to pay them for services voluntarily rendered in the Hill murder case. As in the case of Levings and the other Sherlock Holmeses, they had not ferreted out the guilty party, but had tried to.

As a suggestion, if the \$1600 road pooling fund has not already been spent, let it be used as the foundation for a permanent endowment for aspiring Nick Carters, who are out of a job but are willing to sleuth around the scene of the Ardenwald tragedy. To this endowment might be added the \$200 promised to the East Clackamas County Fair—(Estacada Progress.)

MORE POLITICS

It having been worked to death as a political asset in this county, we note that Multnomah county is now seizing upon the atrocious Hill murder at Ardenwald as a basis for grand-standing. One of the Portland newspapers, assisted by certain gentlemen who will need votes shortly to retain office, appear to have become interested in the crime that shocked all Oregon in 1911, and that has since made many folk disgusted with justice as it is meted out in this

look at them; but that the gas octopus, which has lately invaded our quiet villages and hamlets, usually buries its meters in the cellars or under the mud-sills. Can it be that the gas meters work so fast that the company fears to frighten the eyes of beholders?

The Courier ought to gloat over the fact that it was the only paper published in the English language and having a circulation in the United States, that did not last week say something about the Leo Frank episode.

To make conversation the other day we asked Chris Schuebel what he thought of William E. Stone's plans for reforming the municipal government of the county seat. Mr. Schuebel talked for seven minutes before he stopped. Then we asked him what he thought of George C. Brownell's attack on the prohi law, and he threw up his hands and walked away. He had exhausted his breath and vocabulary on the first subject.

Overheard on the car the other day: First Sweet Thing—"Don't you find these new accordion pleated skirts much more comfortable than those we wore last year?" Second Sweet Thing—"I don't know; after being used to hobbles I feel now as if

Further perusal of government statistics, which we love dearly in spite of John Stark's sarcastic remarks, show us that "American firearms are popular in Columbia"—in fact in 1914 Columbia imported \$10,213 worth from Uncle Sam. The report adds naively that "interest taken in hunting and trap shooting is not commensurate with the facilities of fered." Maybe not; but they have revolutions to make up for this "lack of interest."

Julian H. Arnold, commercial attache of the United States (traveling China last month, reported to Uncle Sam that "it has come to my attention in traveling about China that the demand for American playing cards is on the increase. In Shanghai, for instance, the Chinese are showing preference for Western playing cards over their own so-called sparrow cards. The popularity of the foreign cards could be greatly increased by the addition of Chinese numerals and the Chinese characters for king, queen, and jack. The cheaper grades of playing cards would find a larger market in China than would the more expensive kinds. The Chinese are also fond of showy cards, hence those with pictured backs would be most popular, especially if the backs were designed in Chinese

fashion. Detailed suggestions as to the manner of printing the cards for sale in China and the marketing of the same may be secured from a resident of China, whose address will be furnished upon application by the Bureau of Foreign and Domestic Commerce or its branch offices."

What can our dear missionaries have been doing all this time?

And speaking of missionaries; we met a corporal of marines recently who had just returned from China, and he told us of meeting an American missionary well back in the hill country who was holding frequent services for the little Chinese "heathen" children. This missionary had much sideburns and beard decorating his face, and the corporal of marines asked him why he wore so much hirsute adornment. And the missionary answered, without blushing in the least bit: "I wear my beard this way so as to look like the pictures of Christ, it MAKES IT EASIER TO GET THE MONEY AT COLLECTIONS."

JOHN STARK'S ORATION

Several weeks ago I read a short sketch about a negro who was brought as a slave to Oregon by his white master along sometime in the fifties, I think. The master became hard up and sold the slave his freedom. This brought out a few thoughts on how the traffic of chattel slavery was conducted and also how a "master" could so degrade his own manhood to make merchandise out of other people's liberty. Yet it was the custom of the country; it was lawful and therefore right as long as there was money in it and these masters were imposing upon a despised, ignorant and impoverished class. But times bring changes even in Oregon.

When I read Master Robbins' reply where he says "Having worked my way out of wage and mortgage slavery by long years of faithful service, having bought my freedom and risen to the rank of MASTER, yea verily, triplex master." "Rank of Master," in capital letters, is good. It is indeed "rank" of anyone to be so lost to self respect as to need the title of Master. The negro rose much higher than that it would seem from the simple life sketch. He rose to be a MAN, besides that he beat you in another respect—he got his picture in the paper.

Let us follow out the buying of one's freedom a little further. Because you succeeded in so doing you try a sneer on your masterly countenance because I have failed. The negro bought his freedom, but I hope he is intelligent enough to understand that it was utterly impossible for everyone of his race to purchase his or her freedom. That you fail to comprehend that much gives the Grange a blacker eye than I ever thought of giving, as you told us that

Master only meant a teacher. What can a community or congregation learn when a teacher is so ignorant on common economic problems. A case of the blind leading the sightless.

"I thought I had met a foman of even a higher cast," you simper. You are not buried yet and "life is full of strange romances." You're having a handful of pennies today may not keep you out of the poor house tomorrow. Were it not for the uncertainty of our economic system you would still be a slave—might even be as poor as Stark. I will cheerfully admit that I am a commercial failure and perhaps also in other things. Success, under our economic system, comes to the most cunning, and then often it is only an accident; success meaning getting a wad of course.

The innocent bystander reading your latest would suppose that all grangers are money lenders and Stark was the sole borrower. I am sorry to say the last yet is untrue for I owed all the debts I got into bankruptcy and wipe all the debts off the slate at once and leave all the people free. On the other hand I know that many of the Grangers are in my terrible fix, only it is pathetic to see them trying to hide their distressing poverty. Your pretense that farmers generally and granges particularly are in a prosperous condition is all moonshine. We need only to turn to their resolutions for proof. There is such an alarming debt and distress among the grangers that the subject was a large feature at the Wilmington National meeting last fall. The laymen among them demanded legislation to lift the burden. Instead of the masters in the grange proposing freedom from debts, a scheme was devised by which the individual mortgages should be merged into community bonds to be gambled with by the Wall street sharks. This was brought to the attention of congress as I observed where the grange resolutions on the subject became a part of the Congressional Record. For some reason the scheme was not quite as raw as that put over by the Oregon bunch, but perhaps they are more expert in their treason to the farmers.

You say that you believe all honest debts should be honestly paid. Just what you mean by that would perhaps need amplification. Twenty years ago I was employed in a mine in northern Idaho under the control of General Alger, a republican deity, he of the embalmed beef fame. I have nearly \$200.00 recollection of that incident. Mr. Alger repudiated the debt. The next year was the memorable 16 to one campaign, and Mr. Alger traveled about this land of liberty in a private car making speeches, the burden of which was that "we must be honest and pay our debts in honest money and not in fifty-cent dollars." Well, he is in

(Continued on Page 5)

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